Woodchips in your underwear

The perils of living with a woodturner are not always obvious, as one reader points out to our very own Editor Mark Baker

I've done it again! Forgotten to separate his work clothes from the rest of the washing. All the dark colours have gone in to together and I'm stood here picking woodchips out of my undies... sigh... Will I never learn?!

A couple of years ago I could mix and match my washing at will. All darks together, all whites together, all colours together. Since being with a man that turns, all that has gone out of the window. There is a permanent trail of chips in varying sizes throughout the house. They tumble from him as he walks through, they spill from every pocket, fold and turn-up. They cling to wool, lace and carpets like limpets to a rock.

The big ones aren't too bad, as you can see them easily and pick them up before they have wheedled their way into weaves. The wood dust gets swept up, hoovered or washed away. It's the spiky little so-and-sos that cause the trouble; the grown-up splinters. They have the ability to cling immediately to any fabric and work their way in, hanging on – literally by a thread – as they are washed, spun and dried in the machines. There they nestle, hiding behind the weaves and in the lace, ready to work their way out at the most inconvenient times.

I mean, there you are serving your customer, you move and darn it when something that feels like a spearhead stabs you in the buttock. You wriggle a bit trying to dislodge it and only make it worse. You dare not sit down in case you ram it into your flesh. You try to discreetly tug at the material to lift it from your skin at least, but no, it's still there. So you carry on with the customer, your buttock involuntarily twitching with a mind of its own trying to dislodge the intruder. You eventually escape to the cloakroom to investigate only to find that what seemed like a dagger prodding you in the buttock is a mere 5mm splinter of oak.

PHOTOGRAPH BY MARK BAKER

Fluff *and* chips? It gives a whole new meaning to airing your dirty linen in public...

Then there's the poor old tumble dryer. My friends do battle with fluff in the filter, while I produce a carpet created with the ubiquitous fluff along with wood chips woven together and compacted. I'm sure there must be something useful I can make with it. Rugs for a dolls' house maybe? I'm trying not to think about what goes down the waste pipe from the washer. One day we will get an angry householder further down the waste-pipe chain complaining that they have something jamming their sewer pipe outlet which, when dislodged, will look like a chipboard log.

I have learnt that fitted carpets are a big no. Wood, stone or laminate floors are the only ones to have with a turner in the house. After that, it's a case of how many rugs you are prepared to maintain by vigorously hoovering in both directions to dislodge the chips from the pile, only to find when you look from another angle there are still some diehards clinging on for dear life. I suppose the answer is shagpile in a mix of natural colours, so the little darlings can bury themselves deep out of view and have a perfect disguise. Until you walk barefoot on them of course. Better not go on too long or someone may retaliate with his version of the aftermath of my sewing – bits of threads everywhere, stray pins, having to act as a model while I pin up the hem – or my jewellery making...

For all that, I wouldn't change him for the world (don't tell him, though, or he will stop shaking his clothes before he comes into the house and emptying the pockets or doing the hoovering on a regular basis). The plus side is I live with a continuous stream of beautiful objects that evolve and change as he does in his work. I have lovely things to use and cherish and pieces he makes just for me. I have beads, drops and focals made for my jewellery without complaint. All in all, a small price to pay for a few woodchips in my underwear.

Mrs M-J, via email

Chippendale School sets 2016 course dates

PHOTO COURTESY OF CHIPPENDALE INTERNATIONAL SCHOOL

The Chippendale International School of Furniture has announced four short 'Experience Woodworking Courses' for 2016. The courses will run in January, April, June and September and are for small groups of up to 10 students. Run over a five-day period from Monday to Friday, The Chippendale Experience Courses are very intensive but also a lot of fun. Students will learn a range of woodworking skills and techniques. The many subjects covered will include cutting, sawing and sanding – and the machines involved; Japanese wooden nails; wooden boxes; turning a small bowl; finishes such as Shellac; pyrography; and wood art.

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